

The Bone Keeper

Fantasia Oscura

Chapter I: Awakening in the Shadows

Night descended over the narrow alleys with the heavy weight of the sea wind. The scent of dampness and aged timber filled the room.

In the catacombs beneath the abandoned cathedral, Mateo guards the ossuary of fallen kings. As the northern horde surrounds the city walls, he discovers that the royal bones hold the last breath of ancient magic capable of saving the realm.

The protagonist moved through the narrow corridor driven by an urge that surpassed any caution. Every pine floorboard creaked beneath his boots, echoing through the frame like a muffled heartbeat.

In the most protected corner of the study, atop a walnut desk darkened by time, rested the document. The edges of the paper bore the marks of constant handling and were worn by the passage of decades.

Chapter II: The Crack of Silence

As the oil lamp flared, its flame cast trembling shadows against the stone walls.

Examination of the ink marks revealed information deliberately hidden by local authorities for over three decades. It was no clerical error, but a calculated effort to shield those responsible for the secret.

"If this document reaches the public before dawn," the scribe whispered without taking his eyes off the figures, "the consequences will reach every family in the harbor."

No response came from the threshold. The room's silence was broken only by the steady whistle of the wind through the skylight gaps.

Chapter III: The Incomplete Ledger

At four in the morning, inspection of the second volume confirmed initial suspicions.

The payment entries showed alterations on the central pages. Three consecutive leaves had been sliced out with a surgeon's scalpel, leaving only the binding threads behind.

The protagonist pulled out his pocket magnifier, adjusted the lens over the residual graphite traces, and managed to reconstruct the names of the last two witnesses.

Both were listed as deceased in the 1898 customs registry. Yet naval records indicated they had boarded a southbound vessel three weeks after their official date of death.

Chapter IV: The Estuary Watch

Morning fog began rising over the river waters at six.

The distant blast of freighter horns signaled the start of work at the coal docks. The protagonist wrapped the parchments in a waxed canvas sleeve and locked the leather briefcase with two turns of the key.

He walked slowly along the slick cobblestones of Fishermen's Alley. The harbor taverns were opening their doors, venting the fumes of warm spirits and wet coal onto the street.

Upon reaching Pier Three, the morning tide tugboat was already casting off its stern lines.

Chapter V: The Final Verdict

The resolution of the case took place in the main office of the harbor master before three witnesses of the judicial board.

The document submitted left no room for dispute. The evidence gathered overnight brought a definitive end to the controversy regarding asset ownership and accountability.

The file was archived in the ministry's volume of permanent rulings, sealed with red official wax.

The protagonist left the government building at noon. The rain had cleared, leaving a cold golden light across the harbor arcades. The city carried on with its usual rhythm, unaware of the secret now buried forever.

END OF THE NOVELLA

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